## Assessing the state of maturity of the reforms process in a field

For people who take interest in a field in India—e.g., agricultural reform—it is useful to score the state of maturity at each of the seven stages, every year. At each link in the chain, we should ask: What is the state of knowledge, literature and community? Can we identify ten highly capable persons (of all ideological persuasions) in each stage of the pipeline? A field is in poor shape on stages 1, 2 and 3 if we are not able to envision ten wise persons who can usefully be members of an important expert committee (at stage 4).

This classification system can be used to systematically identify the weak links in the chain in a field of interest, and strengthen those.

## Capacity building for the Indian policy process

> *The best time to plant a tree was 20 years ago. The second best time is now.*
>
> Chinese proverb

Capacity building for Indian policy reform requires fostering capabilities in all seven stages. Successful reforms tend to take place when there is maturity in all the seven areas. Activities that do not fit in the pipeline have limited usefulness. Alpine-style assaults are a high-risk strategy; they will often fail or be reversed.

The pipeline flows from left to right, and therefore there are prerequisites. The early stages have to be complete for the late stages to fare well. A systematic strategy of identifying the gaps—e.g., ‘in field X, there is a particularly important weakness at stage 3’—can lead to constructive strategies to address these gaps.

The seven elements help us think about areas that are ripe for reform versus those that are not. The first four stages of the pipeline are of